

YOUR BABY'S TOP-TO-TOE EXAMINATION

1 Head: Are the soft spots on your baby's skull (the fontanelles), the head shape, head circumference, and hair texture normal?

2 Facial expression: As your baby scrunches up her face in response to a stimulus, is her expression symmetrical? This is a sign of overall well-being.

3 Eyes

- » Do the pupils dilate with changes in light?
- » Is there "red-eye," indicating cataracts?

4 Nose: Is there any mucus blocking the nasal passages, affecting baby's breathing?

5 Cheeks: Does your baby turn to the side when her cheek is stroked? This indicates her response to touch and tests for the "rooting reflex."

6 Mouth

- » Is the roof of your baby's mouth fully formed?
- » Does her tongue move freely, and is it a good color and size?
- » Does your baby suck when the doctor puts his or her little finger inside your baby's mouth?

7 Lips: Does your baby "root for food" when a finger is brushed across the top of her lip?

8 Ears

- » Does your baby turn her head to a sound?
- » Are her ears symmetrical?
- » Are there any skin tags?
- » Do the ears fold forward and backward?
- » When the earlobes are gently pinched, does blood flow back quickly to show healthy circulation?

9 Neck: When the neck is manipulated, does your baby's head bend forward, backward, and from side to side?

10 Collarbone: Was there any injury to the collarbone during birth?

11 Chest:

- » Do your baby's lungs sound clear?
- » Are the heart position and heartbeat correct?

12 Skin

- » Does your baby's skin color show she is getting a healthy level of oxygen?
- » Is there any sign of jaundice (see p.249)?
- » Is your baby's temperature normal?

13 Arms

- » Are the arms proportionate to the baby's size?
- » Does she throw her arms back in the "startle reflex" (also known as the Moro reflex)? If it doesn't happen spontaneously, the doctor will cup your baby's head and safely allow it to seem to fall; this should trigger the reflex.

14 Hands and wrists

- » Does your baby open her fingers as if to hold something when the back of her hand is brushed?
- » Does she grasp the doctor's finger and hold on when it is placed on her palm? She or he will pull her hand upward, raising your baby slightly, to test grip.
- » Are all your baby's fingers there and of the expected length compared with one another?
- » Are there any creases in your baby's palms? Some creases can be a sign of Down syndrome, but there will be other signs with this condition.
- » Do the wrists give the full range of movements?

15 Back

- » Do your baby's shoulder blades look symmetrical?
- » Are there tufts of hair or fat deposits along your baby's spine line? These can indicate spina bifida.
- » Are all the vertebrae there and properly aligned with no unusual kinks or curves?
- » Does gently pressing on the spine seem to cause your baby any pain?

16 Abdomen

- » Are the size and symmetry of the abdomen normal?
- » Do the organs feel normal? For example, it would be normal to be able to feel the edges of the liver, but unexpected to feel the spleen or kidneys.
- » Is the cord stump infected or bleeding?

17 Hips: Is there an appropriate range of movement around the hip joints?

18 Genitals

- » Has your baby passed any meconium, showing that the anus is open?
- » Do genitals look normal and healthy, and have the testicles descended in a boy baby?

19 Legs

- » Are the legs the same length as each other?
- » Do the knees and ankles have full movement?

20 Feet

- » Is the position of the feet at rest normal and are the ankles and the arches of the feet flexible?
- » Is there the correct number of toes and are they of the expected length compared to each other?
- » Is there any webbing between the toes?

Mouth The roof of the mouth is checked to ensure it is fully formed

Skin The color of your baby's skin can be checked in an instant. If it is pink all over, that is a sign of good health

Legs The doctor will manipulate your baby's legs to ensure her knee joints have the correct range of movement



Rooting If anything strokes your baby's cheek, she'll turn her head to root for the object. This reflex ensures successful breast-feeding.